

IN PURSUIT OF THE PERFECT HEIR

With Sunil Chhetri, the leading goalscorer for the Indian national football team, now 39 years old, the country will have to **look for his replacement** sooner rather than later.

Neeladri Bhattacharjee
neeladri.b@thehindu.co.in

The inability to score goals has been the Indian football team's Achilles heel for quite some time now. The last time Igor Stimac's men won a game with a goal off a striker from open play was in June 2023, a 2-0 win against Nepal in the SAFF Championship.

And now, having lost five of its last six games, the morale of the team as well as the fans has deteriorated further after a drop in its FIFA World ranking.

At the AFC Asian Cup 2023 in Qatar, India conceded six goals but failed to score a single one. Amongst 24 teams, it was second from bottom in the xG (expected goals) table, just above Kazakhstan.

The most important reason for this goal drought is the lack of Indians playing as centre-forwards in the Indian Super League (ISL), the top division of men's football in the country.